

Winds of CHANGE

The Congress romped home with a resounding victory winning 32 seats, while the incumbent MNF got just 3

Mizoram voted for change and not just a change of regime in the state, but also a change for the welfare of the people of the hill state, who wanted development and good governance above everything else. So it was that Mizo National Front (MNF) which had been in power for 10 years, was routed to make way for Congress.

The Congress, led by 68-year-old veteran Lalthanhawla, who had been the chief minister of Mizoram thrice before, romped home with a thumping victory, bagging 32 of the total 40 assembly seats, while the MNF led by incumbent chief minister Zoramthanga managed to win just three seats. In the last elections, they had managed 21 seats. Even Zoramthanga's electoral fate was no different from his party's: he suffered humiliating losses in both the seats from where he contested—Champhai north and Champhai south.

Perhaps the most popular of the Congress leaders in the state, many remember Lalthanhawla as the man who gave up his chief ministership

during his first tenure when the peace accord was signed between Delhi and then guerrilla outfit MNF in 1986. The Congress had swept polls in 1984 and he became the chief minister, but chose to step down in 1986 to maintain peace in the state and his modest gesture is remembered till date.

Lalthanhawla, who has been associated with the party for more than 40 years and became a legislator for the first time in 1978, did not have to stay away from the hot seat for long.

In 1989, after the Laldenga-led MNF government fell, he was again made the chief minister. He was chief minister for two consecutive terms between 1989 and 1998 before being ousted by Zoramthanga of the MNF.

"This is the verdict for change and a big snub to the 10-year-old misrule and corruption of the MNF government. We are committed and will focus on development and well being of the people," an ecstatic Lalthanhawla said after the election results were announced on December 8.

Another interesting aspect of the elections in Mizoram was its subdued method of campaigning due to the state's own strict electoral code of conduct issued by the Presbyterian Church. The church-sponsored Mizo People's Forum, an umbrella of NGOs, had issued a 'code of conduct' for parties and candidates to follow during the elections. Television and mobile phones were the only campaign tools allowed ahead of the elections, in sharp contrast to the circus that goes on in other states.

by Elora Sen

MIZORAM ASSEMBLY POLL 08

RESULT	2008	2003
INC	32	12
MNF	3	21
MZPC	2	3
ZNP	2	2
OTHERS	1	2

Total number of seats: 40

it freely distributed tickets to two dozen relatives of MLAs or ministers, though only half of them could win. Moreover, in a very unusual trend, almost every prominent Congress office-bearer lost, including sitting MLA and PCC President C.P. Joshi, who lost by one vote; two former PCC presidents; one Mahila Congress chief besides prominent Jat leaders who were seen as strong contenders for chief ministership. Many wonder if there was anti-incumbency against these prominent Congressmen or their victory chances were sabotaged to make things easier for Gehlot to become the chief minister.

The throne that appears close to Gehlot will still keep

Congressmen are confident that the party will win up to 15 of the 25 seats at stake in the state in the Lok Sabha polls.

him uneasy. One, his candidature is opposed by prominent Jat leaders from the state such as Union Minister Sis Ram Ola, Paras Ram Maderna and Col. Sona Ram. And second, even Brahmins like Joshi and Girija Vyas, chairperson of National Commission of Women, are in the race for the top post. Not just them, governors Naval Kishore Sharma and Shiv Charan Mathur are camping in Jaipur hoping to emerge as consensus candidates. All of them have made it obvious that giving the top post to Gehlot will cost the party dear in terms of Jat votes in the coming Lok Sabha elections. After the surprise win this time, Congressmen are confident that they will win at least 15 of the 25 seats at stake in the parliamentary elections. The rush for power makes Gehlot more worried about his own MLAs than the Independents, eight of whom have already pledged their support to him. Any Congress chief minister, however, will be sailing in the same boat with a fear of rebellion within the party that might work in favour of the BJP.